

Books of The Times

The Boy and the Buffalo

By ORVILLE PRESCOTT

JAMIE. By Jack Bennett. 245 pages. Little, Brown. \$4.50.

IT WAS the year of the great drought in the Buffelsvlakte district in South Africa—some 15 miles from the sea and about as far from the city of Grahamstown. Jamie Carson was 11 years old, as normal, nice and brave a boy as you could hope to meet in a whole library of reminiscent, semi-autobiographical novels. Jamie lived with his father



Jack Bennett

and mother on a farm that had been in the Carson family for generations. What happened during that eventful summer of the drought is the story told by Jack Bennett in his attractive first novel, "Jamie." Although it falls into a familiar and popular subdivision of fiction, it still is daringly unconven-

tional. This is because Jack Bennett is a young, sensitive and talented South African and he has not written about the racial crisis of his unhappy country.

Perhaps Mr. Bennett felt that he could add nothing new to a subject already treated in scores of novels. Perhaps he felt only the compulsion so many novelists endure to write about the world he knew when he was young. In any case, "Jamie" is one of those artfully written books that are intended for adult readers, but that young readers discover and delight in. That's what happened to quite a few of the world's best-beloved books.

"Jamie" is an account of the routine life of a boy on a South African farm complicated by a number of unusual adventures and trials caused by the drought. Mr. Bennett writes a severely simple prose that yet manages to be suggestive and evocative. He understands how a small boy feels, but he does not try to make Jamie a complicated character. Jamie didn't have time to develop any interesting neuroses or any suppressed desires. Jamie loved his parents and his dog. He was a devoted friend to a native boy his own age, Kiewiet, who had "a smile like a watermelon." And Jamie was just realizing that little Jo van de Riet, who lived on a neighboring farm, was very nice.

All this is only the background for the impact of the drought, the misery and ruin it brought and the violence that came in its wake. Jamie's father had been an exceptionally intelligent farmer, but when the

windmills could no longer pump water there was little he could do. And then worse disasters struck and Jamie's world seemed to fall apart. To find some meaning in the ruins he devoted himself to a stubborn and lonely hunt for a vicious bull buffalo, an outcast that had fled the drought and invaded the Carson farm.

Jamie's hunt for the dangerous beast is the climax of Mr. Bennett's story. It is a rousing climax. Equipped with an ancient relic of a gun borrowed from an African poacher, accompanied by Kiewiet, Jamie pursued the buffalo with relentless determination. His hunt marked the crisis that ended his childhood and was in part a sacrifice and a deed of vengeance.

Throughout "Jamie" Mr. Bennett continually evokes the atmosphere of a South African farm—the parched, eroded land; the birds and animals and trees; the life of an isolated community. It is all well done. "Jamie" lacks the emotional impact and psychological interest of a major novel. But in its modest way it is a work of charm and much individual flavor.

End Papers

PHOTOGRAPHS BY CARTIER-BRESSON. By Henri Cartier-Bresson, with introductions by Beaumont Newhall and Lincoln Kirstein. 60 pages. Grossman Publishers/ \$2.50 paperback, \$4 clothbound.

As a conscientious reporter, Cartier refuses to strive for editorial effects. These he leaves to the eye of the beholder by presenting precisely what he sees: the reality of human drama, unstaged, unvarnished.

His special gifts are "a velvet hand, a hawk's eye" that seize the right instant, the right spot and the right arrangement for a memorable picture—a proud boy on an errand, a crippled child playing, the denunciation of a stool pigeon.

Cartier's new book is a superb production by the French printers Draeger Freres. Its



From "Photographs by Cartier-Bresson"

major fault is the editing. Most of these selections have been published and exhibited so frequently that they are as familiar as Strauss waltzes. There is only one 1961 picture, one 1960. The remaining 45 date as far back as 1933. Pages are numbered in the European style; in the gutter, and in print that is inexcusably faint. No captions appear on the picture pages; instead, they are bunched on one forward page. This cuts publishing costs, but it is an exasperating imposition on the reader.

—JOHN S. RADOSTA.